

The Ponderwump

A rhyming picture book for brave little thinkers

written by · illustrated by

The Ponderwump

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In a crooked little cottage at the edge of the wood
lived a girl with a head full of why, how, and could.
Her name, it was Marnie. Behind her bright eyes
spun a carousel wonder, forever surprise.



Her father made worlds out of letters and light,
till a hulking new machine took his desk overnight.
"It's quicker than you," the cold letter had read.
He came shuffling home rather grey, drooping his head.



But Marnie clambered up on his knee with a grin.
"That gadget's not clever. Now listen. Begin.
How many small R's are in strawberry, Dad?"
"The machine answered two." "Then the machine's rather bad,
for the answer is three!" And she spelled it with glee.



Now Mummy sat wrapped in a blanket, unwell,
with a baby curled close, like a pip in its shell.
They kissed her soft cheek. "You're the dearest," they said.
(She still thought "the cloud" was the sky overhead.)



"Go wander," Mum murmured, "and let me lie low."
So they buttoned their coats and they went, off they go,
up over the hill to the Muddlewood, tall,
where the ferns wave like feathers and hush covers all.



"In this forest," breathed Marnie, "a giant abides:
the Ponderwump, wisest of thinkers, who hides.
His thoughts are the biggest for miles, so they say."
Dad smiled, tired and kind. "That's a story, love. Play."



They rambled past toadstools and trickling streams,
till the path petered out and the light thinned to gleams.
"We're turned all about," fretted Daddy. "Oh dear."
But Marnie stood calm. "Then we'll think our way clear."



By a shimmering brook sat a tortoise, forlorn,
all baffled by which mossy stone to step on.
"Just take them in order," said Marnie. "This one, then next."
"The Ponderwump's coat is deep moss, dusk as well."



A long line of ants heaved a crumb like a hill.
"Then break it to pieces," urged Marnie. "Be smart.
One crumb becomes crumbs, and each ant takes a part."
"The Ponderwump's eyes are two lanterns of amber."



A squirrel shot past in a terrible fluster,
his acorns flung wide, all his hoard in a bluster.
"Then gather them gently. Do one, then one again,
repeat it and repeat it, and count up to ten."
"The Ponderwump's horns curl like questions, held high."



An owl on a bough hooted, ruffled and pale.
"Then plan it," said Marnie. "Write steps in a row:
step one, and step two, and step three. Then you go."
"The Ponderwump loops a tail, and wears spectacles, too."



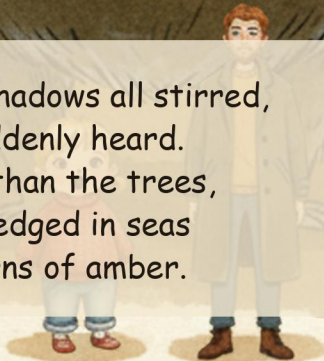
"I believe it. I do." But the trees opened wide
on a river of black, roaring, deep, swift and snide.
Too broad and too bitter to paddle across.
Poor Daddy sank down with a shivery loss.



But a duck on a stump gave a sleepy "just you."
So Marnie described, aloud through the fog,
every twist of the trouble — and clear as could be,
the answer stood up. "A bridge we can make!"



Then the ferns gave a shiver, the shadows all stirred,
and a hum, deep and gentle, was suddenly heard.
Up rose from the gloom, taller far than the trees,
a coat the soft green of the moss, edged in seas
of a dusky blue shimmer; two lanterns of amber.





"The Ponderwump! Look!" Marnie gasped. "There he stands!"
And Daddy just stared, his doubt slipping his hands.
"He's real," Daddy breathed. "All this time you were right.
My clever, brave girl, you could see through the night."



But the great gentle giant slumped down with a moan,
"I've wandered for years, cold and muddled, alone."
So Marnie stood tall by his enormous left toe.
"We'll think it together. Just steady. Just slow."



The Ponderwump brightened. "A plan! Oh, how grand!"
He arched his huge back into one mighty span,
laid his tail like a bridge, and carried them, cradled,
back over the water while stars swept the sky.



"You found one!" laughed Mummy. "A friend, oh how dear!"
Then Daddy knelt down by his girl in the glow.
"A machine took my chair. But now, Marnie, I know:
a mind is a garden no engine can grow."



So the Ponderwump curled in the ferns by their door,
a friend to the family for evermore.
And Marnie slept deep, with the moon on her brow,
and a thought of her own, glowing warm. Wonder how.

For the grown-up reading along

Four quiet ideas hide inside the story, never named so a small child just hears a good tale: putting steps in order (the tortoise), breaking a big job into small pieces (the ants), repeating a step until it is done (the squirrel), and following a clear plan (the owl). Marnie reuses all four to cross the river, so the lessons solve the ending.

A few jokes are for you: the strawberry the machine miscounts, Mummy picturing the cloud in the sky, the squirrel who shipped it and skipped it, and the drowsy duck Marnie explains her problem to.